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THEATRE ARTS

HISTORY OF AFRICAN THEATRE

African Theatre: A History in Five Traditions

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

A short history of performance in Africa: festival and masquerade, the travelling theatre, the school and church stage, protest theatre, and the post-independence play.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- festival
- masquerade
- travelling theatre
- protest theatre
- post-independence drama

This is ZikShare's own teaching text, not a published book. It was written for this library and is free to read, print and use in class. The works listed at the end are the books to read next; they are not reproduced here and are not hosted by ZikShare.

Theatre before the proscenium

The oldest performance traditions in Africa are not plays. They are festivals: the Egungun and Gelede masquerades of the Yoruba, the Eyo and the Osun festival, the Igbo mmanwu, the Bori of the Hausa, the dances and praise-singing of the court and the compound. These are performances with an audience, a text, costume, music, choreography and a meaning, and they are the foundation of the continent's theatre.

Treat them as theatre without turning them into theatre. A masquerade is a religious event before it is a performance; the scholar's job is to describe how it works as performance without pretending it exists to entertain visitors.

The travelling theatre

In the twentieth century the most popular theatre in West Africa was commercial and mobile. The Yoruba travelling theatre companies played in halls and at parties, with a leader who wrote, composed and starred. Hubert Ogunde's company, founded in 1945, toured Nigeria with plays built from folk material, music and satire, and became a national institution; others, including Kola Ogunmola's, made theatre a mass medium before television.

In Ghana the concert party developed a parallel form - a comic sketch, a band, a highlife finale - that toured the country and played to enormous audiences. The concert party is the clearest example in Africa of a popular theatre that was not subsidised and did not need to be.

School, church and university

Colonial education brought the play text and the school concert, and mission churches brought the nativity play and the cantata. The universities added the drama department: Ibadan's School of Drama, founded in 1962, trained the first generation of Nigerian playwrights and directors, and the university theatre became the place where African drama was argued about as literature and as performance.

Protest and liberation

In South Africa, theatre was part of the struggle against apartheid: workshop plays created collectively, performed in halls, churches and townships, and often banned. In Kenya, Ngugi wa Thiong'o's Kamiriithu project made theatre in Gikuyu with villagers and was shut down by the state. In Nigeria, plays about corruption and dictatorship were written, staged and sometimes suppressed.

The lesson of this history is that African theatre has usually been made close to its audience: in a language they speak, in a form they know, about a question that is live. Where it has been most vital, it has also been most at risk.

The archive problem, and what to do about it

African theatre history is written from a thin archive: few published scripts before the 1960s, few recordings, few theatre buildings, and newspapers that are hard to find outside a national library. The history has often been written by outsiders, and the corrections have come from African scholars working with oral sources.

A student project should work with what is local. Record an interview with a performer who worked in the 1970s; collect the programmes of a defunct company; photograph a festival and describe it in performance terms; find the church or school records of a concert. A single well-documented local case is worth more than another summary of the published canon.

Cite the practitioners by name. The history of African theatre is not only the history of playwrights; it is the history of companies, managers, designers, drummers and audiences, and most of them left no book.

Exercises

1. Choose one Nigerian festival and describe its performance elements: costume, music, space, audience, text.
2. Compare a travelling theatre company with a concert party: organisation, repertoire, audience, economics.
3. Read one post-independence play and identify what it takes from festival form and what from the European stage.

Where to read more

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria: A Critical Source Book (1981)

Ebun Clark, Hubert Ogunde: The Making of Nigerian Theatre (1979)

David Kerr, African Popular Theatre (1995)

Ngugi wa Thiong'o, Decolonising the Mind (1986)

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